

Director, AI Operations

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<https://russelldudek.github.io/Ontra/>

Operating objective

Move from distributed AI demand to a governed portfolio of adopted workflows—and make each reviewed case leave useful precedent.

Principles

Tactical empathy before prescription. Read the work and respect what current practices protect.

Governance inside workflow design. Authority, access, review, escalation, and evidence are design inputs.

Value before scale. No unsupported maturity scores or invented ROI; establish baselines and measurement categories.

Local ownership with central coherence. Workflow owners retain accountability while shared precedents reduce repeated invention.

Days 1–30 — Read the work

Listen and observe: executive sponsors, business operations, department leaders, frontline users, IT, security, legal, privacy, procurement, finance, and technical partners.

Map: demand channels, experiments, approved tools, vendor commitments, data classes, human decisions, adoption patterns, and evidence already collected.

Deliverables: AI work map; stakeholder and decision-rights map; discovery hypotheses; baseline measurement categories; first candidate case list.

120-Day Entry Plan

Install the mechanism and prove bounded cases

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Days 31–60 — Install useful boundaries

Create one intake: outcome, workflow friction, owner, users, data, authority, risk, reuse potential, and evidence requirement.

Define intervention patterns: guidance, assistive workflow, bounded automation, agentic pattern, integration, or deliberate no.

Build enablement: office hours, role-based learning, advocates, reusable examples, decision records, and community cadence.

Deliverables: AI Operations charter; precedent template; review path; selected bounded cases; tool/vendor decision criteria; enablement calendar.

Days 61–90 — Prove working cases

Implement: run two or three bounded cross-functional cases with explicit owners and review points.

Instrument: cycle time, completeness, rework, decision quality, exception rate, retained use, user confidence, and operating risk as applicable—without inventing baselines.

Review: compare intended work with actual use; decide what to repair, remain local, standardize, or stop.

Deliverables: first reviewed precedents; evidence packet; adoption review; updated roadmap; learning captured for advocates and technical partners.

Make learning compound

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Days 91–120 — Establish operating cadence

Portfolio review: opportunity, owner, stage, evidence, risk, adoption, reuse potential, and next decision.

Precedent library: publish only reviewed patterns; distinguish reusable clauses from department-specific context.

Community: equip advocates to diagnose work, choose safe patterns, coach peers, and return evidence.

Leadership reporting: concise decisions, blocked value, adoption signals, risk, learning speed, and asks—not activity theater.

Balanced scorecard

Business outcome: workflow-specific value evidence.

Operating behavior: time from qualified demand to bounded proof; decision clarity; repeatable use.

Trust: documented authority, review, escalation, and boundary adherence.

Adoption: retained use, advocate capability, user confidence, and workflow ownership.

Learning speed: precedents established, repaired, kept local, or retired based on evidence.

Day-120 decision

Recommend the next roadmap, operating capacity, tool/vendor posture, governance improvements, and enablement investment from reviewed evidence. The aim is not to centralize every AI decision; it is to make consequential decisions easier, safer, and more reusable.